Charisma Samparani Ututalum

Prof. Charisma Samparani Ututalum, CESE is a Muslimah nurse-educator, academic administrator, and public servant who has served as President of Sulu State University (SSU) — formerly Sulu State College (SSC) — continuously since her election in June 2018. A proud Tausug woman from the province of Sulu, she is widely recognized for steering her institution through a period of dramatic growth, quality assurance reform, and its historic elevation to full university status under Republic Act No. 12296 in 2025. As the first president of Sulu State University, she stands as one of the most consequential higher education leaders in the Bangsamoro region.

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Background

Prof. Charisma S. Ututalum was born and raised in Sulu, a province situated at the southwestern tip of the Philippine archipelago and one of the constituent provinces of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). She belongs to the Tausug people — whose name translates roughly as "people of the current" — a maritime Muslim ethnic group known for their seafaring heritage, rich oral traditions, and a deeply ingrained culture of Islamic faith and communal solidarity.

Her full name often appears with the middle name or family identifier "Samparani," a naming practice common in Tausug society that reflects matrilineal or extended family heritage. Public records note that Engr. Firash Zhed S. Ututalum, known informally as "Dong" and serving as Dean of Student Affairs at Sulu State University, shares the Ututalum surname — pointing to a close-knit family network with meaningful institutional involvement.

Prof. Charisma S. Ututalum, CESE	
	
Born	Sulu, Philippines
Full name	Charisma Samparani Ututalum
Credentials	CESE (Career Executive Service Eligible)
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Tausug
Region	Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
Religion	Islam
Profession	Nurse, Educator, Academic Administrator
Current position	President, Sulu State University
Term began	June 21, 2018 (as SSC President)
Institution	Sulu State University (formerly Sulu State College)
Research interests	Nursing education, generative AI in teaching, psychiatric nursing, higher education in conflict-affected areas

Details of her early childhood remain relatively private, consistent with many Filipino public leaders whose careers and contributions speak more prominently than personal biographical accounts. What emerges clearly from the record is her formation as a Tausug woman who internalized values of *magsabil* (resilience), educational aspiration, and community accountability — values that would define her later leadership style.

Education

Ututalum trained formally as a nurse and built her foundational credentials within the nursing profession. She subsequently pursued advanced academic qualifications, earning doctoral-level credentials that allowed her to be addressed as both Professor and Doctor in various institutional contexts. Her landmark professional qualification is the Career Executive Service Eligibility (CESE), a rigorous certification administered by the Career Executive Service Board of the Philippines that marks readiness for senior leadership roles in the national government and public sector.

Her academic research engagements have spanned nursing education during the COVID-19 pandemic, the integration of generative artificial intelligence in teaching practice, virtues-based approaches in psychiatric nursing education, and broader issues in higher education management within conflict-affected or underserved communities. She has also contributed to open educational resource development through collaborative work with institutions such as the University of the Philippines Open University.

Career

Clinical and Academic Nursing

Before ascending to institutional leadership, Ututalum served as a clinical instructor and faculty member, gaining direct experience in health education delivery. Her nursing background gave her a practical lens through which to understand the intersection of community health, educational access, and public service — particularly relevant in Sulu's complex socio-political environment.

Election as President of Sulu State College

She was elected President of Sulu State College (SSC) on June 21, 2018, and has served continuously since, with her term subsequently extended. Her ascension marked a significant moment for the institution and for Sulu's higher education landscape. Taking the helm of a regional state college in a province historically affected by armed conflict and economic marginalization, she embarked on a multi-pronged agenda of institutional development.

Institutional Development and Quality Assurance

Under her leadership, SSC underwent substantial expansion across enrollment, programs, infrastructure, and institutional systems. Enrollment grew significantly during her tenure, and new academic programs were introduced across disciplines including tourism, public administration, early childhood education, advanced nursing, and information technology. Physical infrastructure improvements included the construction and upgrade of nursing laboratories, administrative buildings, library facilities, and campus-wide Wi-Fi connectivity.

In the area of quality management, the college achieved ISO 9001:2015 certification — a globally recognized standard for quality management systems — and pursued program accreditations through relevant Philippine accrediting bodies. SSC also attained PRIME-HRM Maturity Level 2 recognition from the Civil Service

Commission, affirming the college's human resource management capabilities. Ututalum was re-elected to the Board of Trustees of the Accrediting Agency of Chartered Colleges and Universities in the Philippines (AACCUP), underscoring her recognized standing in national quality assurance governance.

Pandemic Response

When the COVID-19 pandemic reached the Philippines, Ututalum spearheaded the college's community response under the banner of "Pagpahgang ha Covid 19" — a Bayanihan-style initiative that mobilized institutional resources for health and welfare support. She prioritized ensuring that no student was left behind academically, implementing flexible learning modalities, achieving high campus vaccination rates, and maintaining continuity of instruction under extraordinary conditions.

Technology Integration and Community Programs

She championed a SMART campus program that expanded digital infrastructure, along with the adoption of an online library and administrative automation systems. Community-facing programs launched under her watch included organic farming partnerships, scholarship expansions for students from disadvantaged backgrounds, and free bus rides for commuting students — a practical welfare intervention that lowered the daily cost burden of attending college in a resource-constrained province.

Transition to Sulu State University

The capstone achievement of Ututalum's leadership is the successful conversion of Sulu State College into a full state university. Republic Act No. 12296 authorized this transformation, with the law lapsing into effect in September 2025 and the formal institutional transition marked in 2026. As the president who shepherded this process, she became the inaugural president of Sulu State University (SSU).

The conversion fulfilled long-held aspirations within the province and the broader Bangsamoro region for a flagship state university anchored in Sulu. SSU is positioned with a mandate toward technological, professional, and vocational excellence, while also advancing research, cultural preservation, and regional development. The milestone is regarded as a significant contribution to peace-building and socio-economic progress in BARMM, expanding access to quality higher education for Tausug youth closer to home.

International Engagement

Ututalum has represented SSC/SSU at international academic events in Japan (notably the International Network for Quality Assurance Agencies in Higher Education, or INQAAHE), Turkey, and New York, where she engaged with Filipino educators abroad. She has served as a keynote speaker at international conferences, and has engaged in global partnerships aimed at enriching the university's academic profile and research visibility.

Recognition

Among the recognitions she has received:

- **Most Outstanding Governance and Leadership Award in the Academe** — a distinction recognizing exceptional institutional leadership

- **Re-election to the AACCUP Board of Trustees** — affirming national-level trust in her quality assurance expertise
- **Gawad Sulo ng Pamumuno** — a local honor recognizing distinguished leadership in the Sulu context
- Various institutional and community recognitions tied to her pandemic response initiatives and higher education contributions

Personal Values and Cultural Significance

Those familiar with her leadership describe a figure who combines approachability with vision — a leader whose commencement messages and community programs consistently reflect what colleagues characterize as a genuine "heart for service." She balances professional ambition with cultural sensitivity, actively promoting Tausug identity within the institution while embracing contemporary imperatives around innovation, sustainability, and inclusivity.

Her research and programmatic interests in Halal-aligned development, Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) integration, and organic agriculture reflect a leadership philosophy that seeks to root the university's development within the cultural and ecological context of Sulu.

As a contemporary Tausug woman in a high-profile public institutional role, Ututalum has become a source of inspiration for young people across Mindanao — particularly young women and girls — who see in her a model of how local identity, professional excellence, and community commitment can converge into transformative leadership. Her trajectory also illustrates the expanding role of women in governance and academic administration within the Bangsamoro region.

Legacy

Prof. Charisma S. Ututalum's legacy is still actively being written. As the founding president of Sulu State University, she inherits the twin mandates of consolidating hard-won institutional gains and charting new directions for a province whose youth have long deserved world-class educational infrastructure. Her tenure has demonstrated that even in regions marked by historical conflict and resource constraints, committed institutional leadership rooted in cultural pride and genuine service can produce measurable, lasting transformation.

Her story is significant not only for what she has built but for what she represents: a Tausug woman who turned educational access into a form of peacebuilding, and who led her community's university from a state college to a full university one milestone at a time.

See Also

- Sulu State University
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Tausug people
- Commission on Higher Education (Philippines)
- Accrediting Agency of Chartered Colleges and Universities in the Philippines (AACCUP)
- Career Executive Service Board (Philippines)

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